

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Can Chicago make streets safe for walking, cycling to school?

Progress has been made in recent years, but advocates say more needs to be done

By Sarah Macaraeg
Chicago Tribune

Eager to finish tuning up bikes that they'd been learning how to fix since fall, the high school students in West Town Bike's after-school program fell quiet when their instructor asked for a show of hands.

High school senior Christopher Garcia was one of three students who raised their hands when the instructor asked if they'd been hit by a vehicle while cycling.

The trio are among at least 2,860 Chicago pedestrians or cyclists ages 1 to 19 who've been hit by cars since 2021, according to a Tribune review of collisions logged by the Chicago Police Department.

Low-cost interventions that Chicago and other cities have added to select streets in the last two decades to make school routes safer for students to walk and bike to school have brought communities lasting benefits — and spurred a precipitous decline

in injuries, experts say.

But local data suggests much work is to be done.

Traffic crashes accounted for 39 deaths, among pedestrians and cyclists under age 20 in Cook County between 2018 and 2022, the most recent years of Centers for Disease Control and Prevention mortality data available.

The Chicago Department of Transportation has ushered in a range of general pedestrian and cyclist safety projects in recent years, which the agency credits

with allowing Chicago to outpace all other major cities in cycling growth.

Yet, a new initiative by the department focusing on schools last year was limited to only 10 sites among more than 600 schools in Chicago Public Schools.

Given the preventable nature of crashes, far more safety initiatives are needed, students, advocates and parents who spoke with the Tribune said, as danger remains in

Turn to Safety, Page 2

Illinois Dems plot Trump pushback

State's congressional delegation plans ways to limit scope of policies

By Daniel C. Vock
Chicago Tribune

WASHINGTON — One week before Donald Trump moves back into the White House, the Democrats representing the Chicago area in Congress are strategizing ways to limit the scope of the Republican president-elect's plans.

Trump and his GOP allies have signaled that they would quickly target Illinois and other Democratic bastions once Trump assumes the presidency and as Republicans now control both chambers of Congress.

Tom Homan, Trump's pick to lead immigration enforcement, told Chicago supporters last month that mass deportations would "start right here in Chicago, Illinois." Congressional Republicans have teed up legislation to strip so-called sanctuary cities like Chicago of federal funds that could be used to help immigrants in the country illegally. And much of Trump's larger agenda — from launching trade wars, pulling back federal support for electric vehicles or eschewing scientific research — could affect Illinois residents and the state's economy.

"Trump has not been kind in his descriptions of Chicago," said U.S. Rep. Jan Schakowsky, who represents parts of Chicago and many northern suburbs. "There's definitely going to be a lot of push-back (from Illinois officials), and it'll be obvious what Trump is doing: He wants to punish certain blue states."

Still, Illinois Democrats figure they have an avenue for some success in the latest Trump era.

They hope they can get Republicans to back off on some demands when the GOP will undoubtedly need help passing high-priority bills. Chicago-area lawmakers also plan to enlist business allies in their fight against higher tariffs and immigration raids and promote bipartisan proposals while Trump pursues a more polarizing agenda.

Turn to Democrats, Page 4



E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Students pitch ideas for safer roads

Christopher Garcia, 18, a senior at Intrinsic Schools' Belmont campus, tests out a bike at the After School Matters program at West Town Bikes in the Humboldt Park neighborhood on Dec. 3. He said he wishes that spaces for bikes separate from cars were more of a norm rather than the exception. The Chicago Department of Transportation completed 10 projects in the last year near schools around the city to improve pedestrian and cyclist safety following crashes involving students. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

16 dead in Los Angeles area as fire crews scramble

16 more missing as warnings issued on big winds, dry air

By Christopher Weber
and Holly Ramer
Associated Press

LOS ANGELES — Firefighters scrambled Sunday to make further progress against wildfires that have destroyed thousands of homes and killed 16 people in the Los Angeles area as forecasters again warned of dangerous weather with the return of strong winds this week. At least 16 people were missing, and authorities said that number was expected to rise.

The National Weather Service issued red flag warnings for severe fire conditions through Wednesday, with sustained winds of 50 mph and gusts in the mountains reaching 70 mph. The most dangerous day will be Tuesday, meteorologist Rich Thompson said.

"You're going to have really strong gusty Santa Ana winds, a

very dry atmosphere and still very dry brush, so we still have some very critical fire weather conditions out there," Thompson said at a community meeting Saturday night.

Los Angeles County Fire Chief Anthony Marrone said 70 additional water trucks arrived to help crews fend off flames spread by renewed gusts: "We are prepared for the upcoming wind event."

Fierce Santa Anas have been largely blamed for turning the wildfires sparked last week into infernos that leveled entire neighborhoods around the city, which has seen no significant rainfall in more than eight months.

LA Mayor Karen Bass said Sunday that she has spoken with members of the incoming presidential administration and said she expects President-elect Donald Trump will visit the region.

Twelve people were missing within the Eaton Fire zone and four were missing from the Palisades Fire, Los Angeles County

Turn to Fires, Page 9



The sun rises behind a home destroyed by the Palisades Fire in the Pacific Palisades community of Los Angeles on Sunday. **NOAH BERGER/AP**

DeRozan returns to face Bulls

Former Bulls All-Star makes his first visit to the United Center since joining Sacramento this season, scoring 21 points as the Kings beat the Bulls 124-119. **Chicago Sports**

Band puts spin on classic literature

Local band Mortal Fools, which performs rock versions of literary works by Shakespeare and Milton, has an upcoming show adapting Homer's "Odyssey." **Arts & Living**

Americans' view of Biden wanes

As Biden prepares to leave office, Americans have a dimmer view of his presidency than they did at the end of Trump's first term, a new poll finds. **Nation & World**

TODAY'S
WEATHER



High 19 Low 8

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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